Self-Perception Profile for Children

Description and purpose

Self-perception is important because a child's idea of themselves informs how they behave socially and the social initiative and control they display. Children with positive self-perception expect others to see them positively too and this can lead to rewarding interactions with others. Children with poor self-perception carry many doubts and anxieties about themselves and expect others to see them as similarly inadequate or bad.

The Self-Perception Profile for Children is a widely used and well-regarded instrument which covers five domains of self-competence or self-adequacy together with a self-assessment of global self-worth (Harter, 1985). There are therefore six subscales. The competency domains are scholastic competence and athletic competence. The other three domains are social acceptance, physical appearance and behavioural conduct. The scale was originally developed and evaluated for children between 8 and 13 years. Users of the instrument are strongly recommended to refer to Harter (1999) for a comprehensive account of the theoretical and research background of the instrument and an excellent chapter on interventions to promote adaptive self-evaluations. An anglicised version of the scale 'What I Am Like' was evaluated in the UK on a representative sample (4282) of Scottish children from 8 to 15 years (Hoare, Elton, Greer and Kerley, 1993a). It is this version of the scale that is reproduced here, together with data from the Scottish study.

This measure requires the children or young people to make an evaluation of themselves. It is therefore an extremely useful triangulation when the adults around the child, in particular teachers, have concerns. This scale will provide evidence about how the child or young person perceives their competence and skills. Research indicates that there are often significant differences between how children or young people see themselves and how they are perceived by teachers and other significant adults (Harter, 1982). Rather than relying on adult perspectives it is important to obtain the perspectives of children and young people themselves. The Self-Perception Profile for Children offers a well-researched, reliable and valid means of achieving this.

The assumptions underpinning the measure are that by 8 years of age children:

- Are able to identify different domains of competence/adequacy and will not feel equally competent in every skill domain.
- Have developed a generalised concept of self which is not simply a summation of judgements about their competences across a range of specific abilities or attributes, but rather an independent judgement about their worth as a person.

Exploration of the profile of scores (across the five self-perception domains and global self-worth scale) is therefore seen as an important outcome of the self-assessment.

Structure of the subscales

- The scholastic competence scale taps into the child's perception of his/her competence or ability in school work: being good/not good at school work, being clever/not clever, being quick/slow at finishing.
- The social acceptance scale taps into the degree to which the child is accepted by peers or feels popular: finding it hard/easy to make friends, wanting to have more friends/having as many as they want, being/not being popular.
- The athletic competence subscale taps into perceived competence in sport and outdoor games: doing well/not doing well at all kinds of sports, watching rather than playing or vice versa, wishing to be a lot better at sport/feeling good enough.

- The physical appearance subscale taps into the degree to which the child is happy with the way they look: happy/not happy with their height and weight, wish they looked different/like it as they are, think/don't think they are good looking.
- The behavioural conduct subscale taps into the degree to which children like the way they behave: do/don't do the right thing, do/don't do things that get them into trouble, behave themselves well/find it hard to behave well.
- The global self-worth subscale taps into the extent to which the child likes him or herself as a person and differs from the other scales in that it does not refer to domain specific competence or adequacy: being unhappy/pleased with oneself, like the kind of person they are/wishing they were someone else, like/don't like the way they are leading their life.

Revision of the original instrument

An anglicised version of the scale produced by Hoare et al. (1993a) for the Scottish standardisation study is included here. As the result of a pilot study in two Scottish schools, the following wording changes were made to the original to ensure comprehensibility to British children:

1. Question 1: 'school work assigned to them' to 'their school work'.
2. Question 7: 'just as smart as other kids their own age' to 'just as clever as other kids'.
3. Question 7: 'wonder if they are as smart' to 'wonder if they are as clever'.
4. Question 15: 'well at just about any new sports activity they haven't tried before' to 'well at any new sport'.
5. Question 15: 'may not do well at sports they haven't even tried' to 'do not do well at new sports'.
6. Question 17: 'act' to 'behave'.
7. Question 21: 'better than others their age at sports' to 'better at sports than their friends'.
8. Question 22: 'Some kids wish their physical appearance (how they look) was different' to 'Some kids wish they looked different'.
9. Question 22: 'Other kids like their physical appearance the way it is' to 'Other kids like the way they look'.
10. Question 31: 'figure out' to 'work out'.

Administration

The scale can be administered in groups as well as individually. After filling out the information at the top of the scale, children are instructed as to how to answer the questions. A script for the administrator is provided below. For children aged 7–8 years, it is best to read the questions aloud and for the group to move through the questionnaire in unison. For ages 9 years upwards, children can be left to proceed once the instructions have been completed. The scale is best introduced as a survey with some exploration that children generally understand what this means. It is essential to make clear that for any given question only one box on either side is checked (some monitoring of the group is recommended to ensure that this is understood).

Here at the top of your sheet it says 'What I Am Like'. We have some sentences here to find out about you.

This is not a test, it is a survey. Who can tell me what a survey is?

(Acknowledge any response with a brief encouraging response, e.g. 'good'.)

For example, suppose I asked you what kind of chocolate bar you liked, Mars or Kit-Kat. There isn't a right or wrong answer, it's just your choice. So the survey you are going to fill out is about you, what you think about yourself and there aren't any right or wrong answers, it's just your opinion.

I'll explain what we do. Look at these examples. I'll read the first one and you listen. [Read item a]. *This question talks about two kinds of children. We want to know which is most like you.*

1. *This is what I want you to do. First, decide if you are like this or like this* [point]. *If you are like this* [point] *– do you like to play outside? Or are you more like this* [point] *– do you like to watch TV? Don't mark anything yet.*

2. *Now you have chosen this answer – you like playing outside/watching TV. Is this really true for you?* [point to the furthest box] *You really like ..... more than .....? Or is this only sort of true for you?* [point to closest box] *Mark that box.*

3. *For each question, you only choose one box. Sometimes it will be on one side of the page, sometimes it will be on the other side. Put a tick in the box.*

4. *Now here are some more sentences. I'll read them to you and you choose one side, then one box. Choose the box that goes with what is true for you, what you are most like.*

Scoring

There are six items to each of the six subscales making 36 items in all. Within each subscale, three of the items are worded such that the first part of the statement reflects high competence or adequacy and the other three are worded such that the first part of the statement reflects low competence or adequacy.

The unique question format is designed to offset the tendency to give socially desirable responses. The child is first asked to decide which kind of child he or she is most like by presenting him/her with two contrasting alternatives (for example, 'some children often forget what they learn' as opposed to 'other children can remember things easily'). Having made that decision, the child is then asked to decide whether the description is 'sort of true' or 'really true' for them.

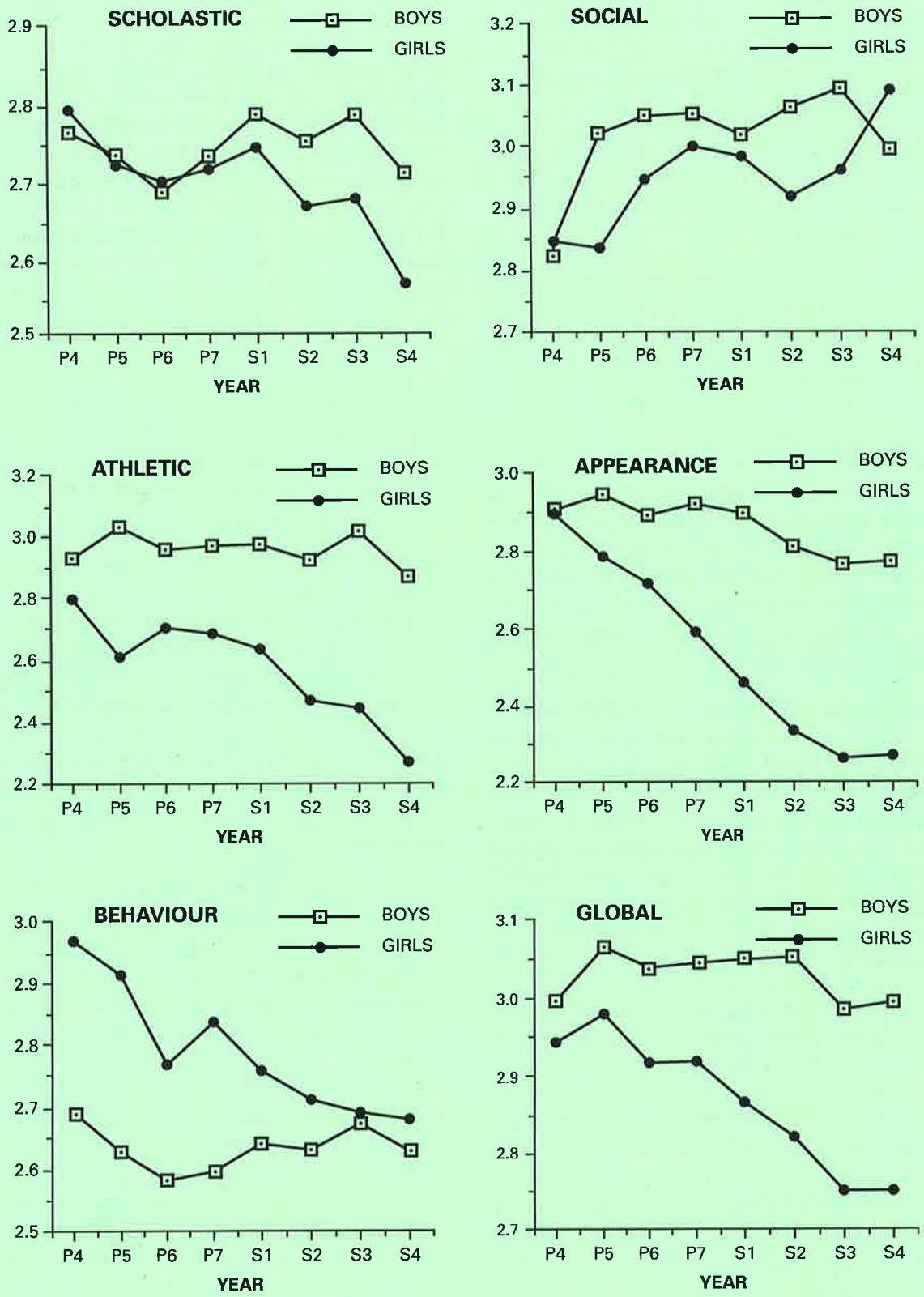
Each item is scored on a four-point scale, with a higher score reflecting a higher perceived competence. In the above example, a child would score 1 on this item if they first decided that they were more like the kind of child who forgets what they learn and then decided that this description is 'really true' for them. If, having decided that they were more like the kind of child who forgets what they learn, the child then decides whether this description is 'sort of true' for them, they would score 2. On the other hand, a child who decided that they were like those children who can remember things easily, but that it was 'sort of true' for them would score 3, while one who first decided that they were like those children who can remember things easily, but that it was 'really true' for them would score 4.

A Scoring Grid is provided to assist with the scoring of the scales. Items are scored 4, 3, 2 or 1, where 4 represents the most adequate self-judgement and 1 represents the least adequate self-judgement. Items are counterbalanced so that 'least competent' and 'most competent' descriptions appear on the left- or right-hand sides. It can be seen from the Scoring Grid that when the most competent description appears on the left-hand side, scores for the response options decrease from 4 to 1 across the page. When the least competent description appears on the left-hand side, scores for the response options increase from 1 to 4 across the page. A summary Scoring Sheet is also provided, which allows scores to be grouped by subscale. Mean scores can then be plotted on an individual profile form also included.

With possible scores of 1, 2, 3 or 4, the midpoint score for each question is 2.5. In the Scottish sample, average scores varied between 2.26 and 3.05. The standard deviations ranged from 0.48 to 0.72, which suggest considerable variation between individuals. Boys rated themselves higher than did girls on most of the subscales. The one scale on which the pattern was reversed being the behaviour subscale, where girls' ratings were higher than those of boys, particularly in the primary school years.

Patterns of scoring in the Scottish sample on all subscales are presented in Figure 1.3. The Scottish class groups P4 to P7 equate to age 7–10 years and S1 to S4 equate to age 11–14 years. The sex differences reported in the Scottish sample are closely similar to those obtained in the US and internationally (Harter, 1999). The sex difference in favour of boys was most clearly demonstrated in the athletic, appearance and global self-worth subscales, where boys' scores remained relatively stable across the age range, while girls' scores progressively declined with age. On the scholastic subscale the mean scores were very similar for boys and girls in the primary school years, but diverged at secondary school where boys' scores remained relatively stable while girls' scores declined with age. The social subscale differed from the other

Figure 1.3 Modified Harter subscale mean scores for boys and girls



Source: Taken from Hoare et al. (1993a: 24)

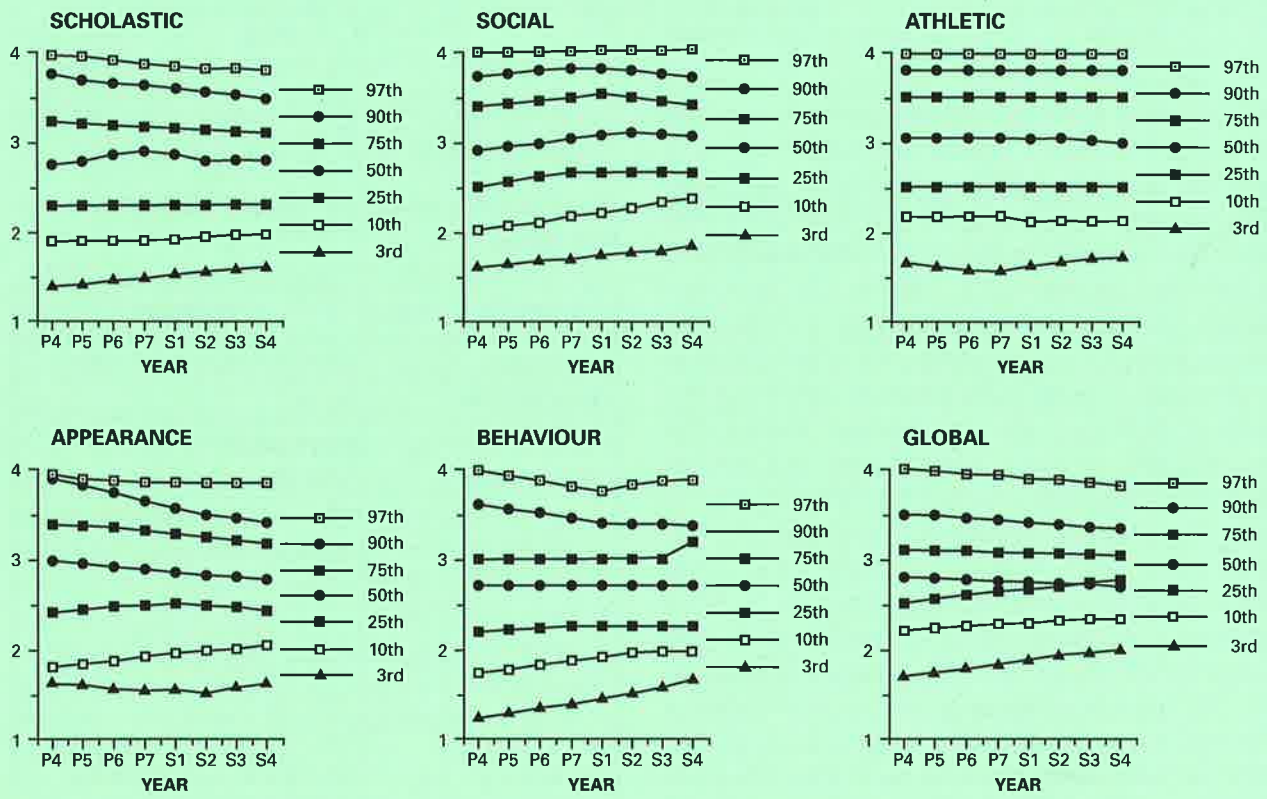
subscales in two ways: first, differences between the sexes were small and inconsistent and, second, scores tended to show an increase with age, rather than a decrease.

Interpretation

The mean scores and the variations with age and gender described above should all be borne in mind when it comes to the interpretation of the scores for an individual pupil. The normative data presented in Figures 1.4 and 1.5 allows the scores obtained by children who are at higher risk in terms of mental health and well-being to be converted to centile scores and compared with the distribution of scores obtained by the general population sample of children in the Scottish study (Hoare and Mann, 1994). Centile scores for boys are presented in Figure 1.4 and for girls in Figure 1.5.

A centile score of 50 is average, with half of the children of a particular age scoring below and half above. The centile score corresponding to each of the mean scores should be added to the child's profile. Hoare et al. (1993b) caution that because of the wide range of centile values on each subscale, a child can only be categorised as outside the normal range if their average score on a subscale is 1. However, in using the measure for prevention and early intervention, the centile tables may be used to identify scores that warrant further investigation. For example, a score at or below the 10th centile is low, placing a child in the bottom 10 per cent of children of that age. Scores at or below the 10th centile, even in a single domain, may be worth further consideration. Scores below the 3rd centile will usually warrant further investigation.

Figure 1.4 Centile scores for boys (Hoare et al., 1993b)



References

Harter, S. (1982). The perceived competence scale for children. *Child Development*, 53, 87–97.

Harter, S. (1985). *Manual for the Self-Perception Profile for Children*. Denver: University of Denver.

Harter, S. (1999). *The Construction of Self: A Developmental Perspective*. New York: Guilford Publications.

Hoare, P., Elton, R., Greer, A. and Kerley, S. (1993a). The modification and standardisation of the Harter Self-Esteem Questionnaire with Scottish school children. *European Child and Adolescent Psychiatry*, 2(1), 9–33.

Hoare, P., Elton, R., Greer, A. and Kerley, S. (1993b). The standardisation of the Harter Self-Esteem Questionnaire with Scottish school children. Unpublished data, available from the authors.

Hoare, P. & Mann, H. (1994). Self-esteem and behavioural adjustment in children with epilepsy and children with diabetes. *Journal of Psychosomatic Research*, 38(8), 859-869.

Renick, M.J. and Harter, S. (1989). Impact of social comparisons on the developing self-perceptions of learning disabled students. *Journal of Educational Psychology*, 81, 631–638.

THE SELF-PERCEPTION PROFILE FOR CHILDREN

GL Assessment

Name ..... Date .....

Age ..... Class ..... Please circle: Male / Female

	Really true for me	Sort of true for me	SAMPLE SENTENCE			Sort of true for me	Really true for me
a.			Some kids would rather play outside in their spare time.	BUT	Other kids would rather watch TV.		

	Really true for me	Sort of true for me				Sort of true for me	Really true for me
1.			Some kids feel they are very good at their school work.	BUT	Other kids worry about whether they can do their school work.		
2.			Some kids find it hard to make friends.	BUT	Other kids find it's pretty easy to make friends.		
3.			Some kids do very well at all kinds of sports.	BUT	Other kids don't feel they are good when it comes to sports.		
4.			Some kids are happy with the way they look.	BUT	Other kids are not happy with the way they look.		
5.			Some kids often do not like the way they behave.	BUT	Other kids usually like the way they behave.		
6.			Some kids are often unhappy with themselves.	BUT	Other kids are pretty pleased with themselves.		
7.			Some kids feel they are just as clever as other kids.	BUT	Other kids aren't so sure and wonder if they are clever.		
8.			Some kids have a lot of friends.	BUT	Other kids don't have very many friends.		
9.			Some kids wish they could be a lot better at sports.	BUT	Other kids feel they are good enough at sports.		
10.			Some kids are happy with their height or weight.	BUT	Other kids wish their height or weight was different.		
11.			Some kids usually do the right thing.	BUT	Other kids often don't do the right thing.		
12.			Some kids don't like the way they are leading their life.	BUT	Other kids do like the way they are leading their life.		
13.			Some kids are pretty slow in finishing their work at school.	BUT	Other kids can do their school work quickly.		
14.			Some kids would like to have a lot more friends.	BUT	Other kids have as many friends as they want.		
15.			Some kids think they could do well at any new sport.	BUT	Other kids are afraid they do not do well at new sports.		

© Harter 1985. Adapted by Hoare et al 1993. Reproduced by kind permission of the authors.
This measure is part of *Measures in Children's Mental Health & Psychological Wellbeing: A Portfolio for Education & Health Professionals*, edited by Norah Frederickson and Sandra Dunsmuir.
Published by GL Assessment, 9th Floor, 389 Chiswick High Road, London, W4 4AJ.

THE SELF-PERCEPTION PROFILE FOR CHILDREN

GL Assessment

	Really true for me	Sort of true for me				Sort of true for me	Really true for me
16.			Some kids wish their body was different.	BUT	Other kids like their body the way it is.		
17.			Some kids usually behave the way they know they're supposed to.	BUT	Other kids often don't behave the way they know they're supposed to.		
18.			Some kids are happy with themselves as a person.	BUT	Other kids are often not happy with themselves.		
19.			Some kids often forget what they learn.	BUT	Other kids can remember things easily.		
20.			Some kids are always doing things with a lot of kids.	BUT	Other kids usually do things by themselves.		
21.			Some kids feel they are better at sports than their friends.	BUT	Other kids don't feel they can play as well.		
22.			Some kids wish they looked different.	BUT	Other kids like the way they look.		
23.			Some kids usually get in trouble because of things they do.	BUT	Other kids don't do things that get them into trouble.		
24.			Some kids like the kind of person they are.	BUT	Other kids often wish they were someone else.		
25.			Some kids do very well at their class work.	BUT	Other kids don't do very well at their class work.		
26.			Some kids wish more people their own age liked them.	BUT	Other kids feel that most people their own age do like them.		
27.			In games and sports, some kids usually watch instead of play.	BUT	Other kids usually play rather than just watch.		
28.			Some kids wish something about their face or hair was different.	BUT	Other kids like their face and hair the way it is.		
29.			Some kids do things they know they shouldn't do.	BUT	Other kids hardly ever do things they know they shouldn't do.		
30.			Some kids are very happy being the way they are.	BUT	Other kids wish they were different.		
31.			Some kids have trouble working out the answers in school.	BUT	Other kids almost always can work out the answers.		
32.			Some kids are popular with others their own age.	BUT	Other kids are not very popular.		
33.			Some kids don't do well at new outdoor games.	BUT	Other kids are good at new games right away.		
34.			Some kids think they are good looking.	BUT	Other kids think that they are not very good looking.		
35.			Some kids behave themselves very well.	BUT	Other kids often find it hard to behave themselves.		
36.			Some kids are not happy with the way they do a lot of things.	BUT	Other kids think the way they do things is fine.		

© Harter 1985. Adapted by Hoare et al 1993. Reproduced by kind permission of the authors.
This measure is part of *Measures in Children's Mental Health & Psychological Wellbeing: A Portfolio for Education & Health Professionals*, edited by Norah Frederickson and Sandra Dunsmuir.
Published by GL Assessment, 9th Floor, 389 Chiswick High Road, London, W4 4AJ.

THE SELF-PERCEPTION PROFILE FOR CHILDREN

GL Assessment

Scoring Grid

1.	4	3	School work	2	1
2.	1	2	Make friends	3	4
3.	4	3	Sports	2	1
4.	4	3	Way they look	2	1
5.	1	2	Behave	3	4
6.	1	2	Unhappy with themselves	3	4
7.	4	3	Clever	2	1
8.	4	3	Friends	2	1
9.	1	2	Sports	3	4
10.	4	3	Weight	2	1
11.	4	3	Right thing	2	1
12.	1	2	Leading their life	3	4
13.	1	2	School work	3	4
14.	1	2	Friends	3	4
15.	4	3	Do well at sports	2	1
16.	1	2	Body	3	4
17.	4	3	Behave the way supposed to	2	1
18.	4	3	Happy as person	2	1
19.	1	2	Remember things	3	4
20.	4	3	Doing things with lots of kids	2	1
21.	4	3	Better than friends at sports	2	1
22.	1	2	How they look	3	4
23.	1	2	Get in trouble	3	4
24.	4	3	Person they are	2	1
25.	4	3	Do well at class work	2	1
26.	1	2	More people like them	3	4
27.	1	2	Watch rather than play	3	4
28.	1	2	Face and hair	3	4
29.	1	2	Do things they shouldn't	3	4
30.	4	3	Happy the way they are	2	1
31.	1	2	Working out answers	3	4
32.	4	3	Popular	2	1
33.	1	2	New outdoor games	3	4
34.	4	3	Good looking	2	1
35.	4	3	Behave well	2	1
36.	1	2	Way do things	3	4
			TOTALS		

© Harter 1985. Reproduced by kind permission of the author.
This measure is part of *Measures in Children's Mental Health & Psychological Wellbeing: A Portfolio for Education & Health Professionals*, edited by Norah Frederickson and Sandra Dunsmuir.
Published by GL Assessment, 9th Floor, 389 Chiswick High Road, London, W4 4AJ.

THE SELF-PERCEPTION PROFILE FOR CHILDREN

GL Assessment

Scoring Sheet

		Scholastic Competence	Social Acceptance	Athletic Competence	Physical Appearance	Behavioural Conduct	Global Self-Worth
1.	School work						
2.	Make friends						
3.	Sports						
4.	Way they look						
5.	Behave						
6.	Unhappy with themselves						
7.	Clever						
8.	Friends						
9.	Sports						
10.	Weight						
11.	Right thing						
12.	Leading their life						
13.	School work						
14.	Friends						
15.	Do well at sports						
16.	Body						
17.	Behave the way supposed to						
18.	Happy as person						
19.	Remember things						
20.	Doing things with lots of kids						
21.	Better than friends at sports						
22.	How they look						
23.	Get in trouble						
24.	Person they are						
25.	Do well at class work						
26.	More people like them						
27.	Watch rather than play						
28.	Face and hair						
29.	Do things they shouldn't						
30.	Happy the way they are						
31.	Working out answers						
32.	Popular						
33.	New outdoor games						
34.	Good looking						
35.	Behave well						
36.	Way do things						
	Subscale Score						
		÷ 6	**÷ 6**	**÷ 6**	**÷6**	**÷6**	**÷6**
	Mean Score						

© Harter 1985. Reproduced by kind permission of the author.
This measure is part of *Measures in Children's Mental Health & Psychological Wellbeing: A Portfolio for Education & Health Professionals*, edited by Norah Frederickson and Sandra Dunsmuir.
Published by GL Assessment, 9th Floor, 389 Chiswick High Road, London, W4 4AJ.

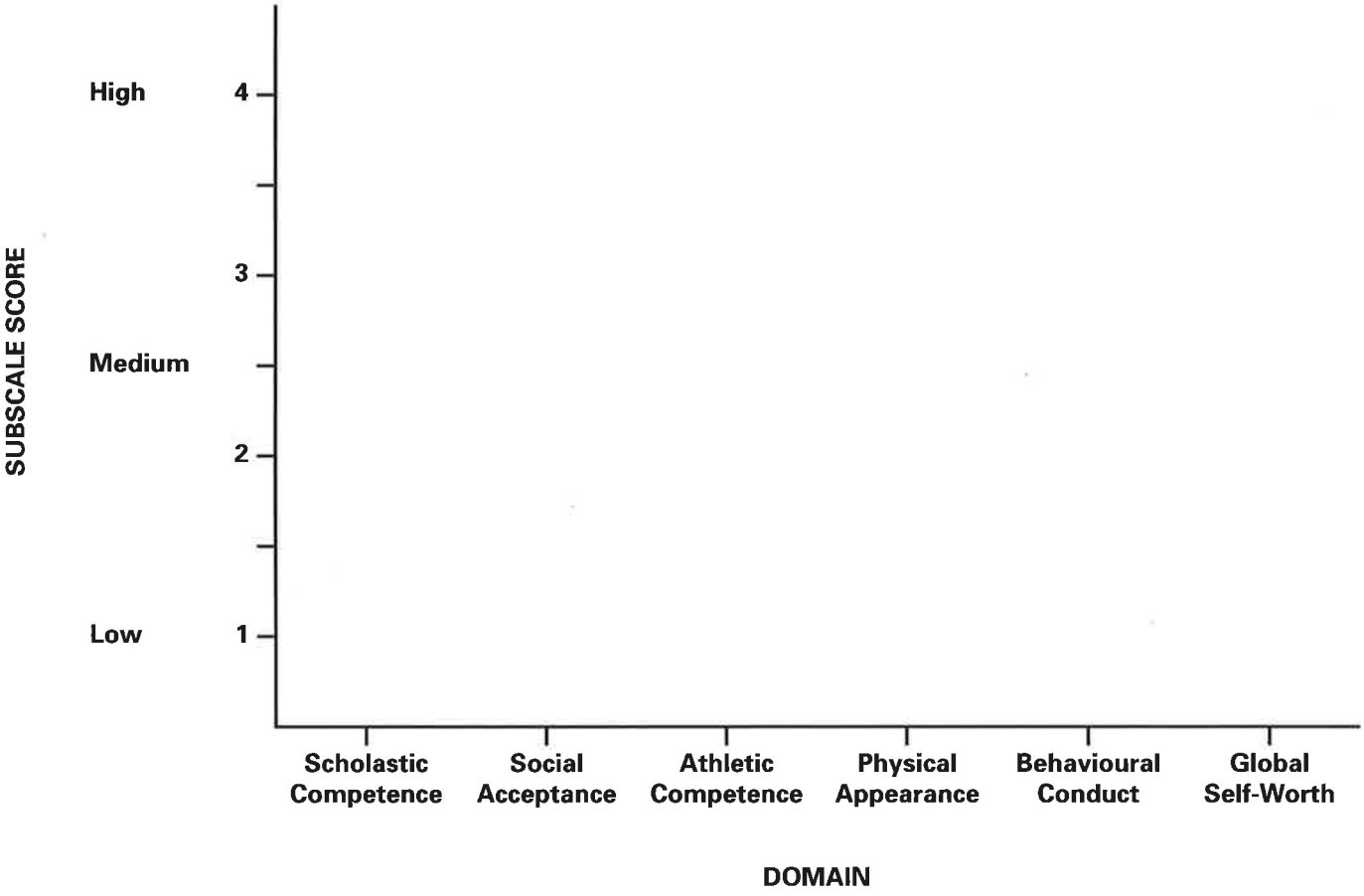
THE SELF-PERCEPTION PROFILE FOR CHILDREN

GL Assessment

Profile Form

Name ..... Date .....

Age ..... Class ..... Please circle: Male / Female



© Harter 1985. Reproduced by kind permission of the author.
This measure is part of *Measures in Children's Mental Health & Psychological Wellbeing: A Portfolio for Education & Health Professionals*, edited by Norah Frederickson and Sandra Dunsmuir.
Published by GL Assessment, 9th Floor, 389 Chiswick High Road, London, W4 4AJ.

THE IMPORTANCE SCALE

GL Assessment

Name ..... Date .....

Age ..... Class ..... Please circle: Male / Female

How important are these things to how you feel about yourself as a person?

	Really true for me	Sort of true for me				Sort of true for me	Really true for me
1.			Some kids think it is important to do well in school work in order to feel good as a person.	BUT	Other kids don't think how well they do at school work is that important.		
2.			Some kids don't think that having a lot of friends is all that important.	BUT	Other kids think that having a lot of friends is important to how they feel as a person.		
3.			Some kids thinks it's important to be good at sports.	BUT	Other kids don't think how good you are at sports is that important.		
4.			Some kids think it's important to be good looking in order to feel good about themselves.	BUT	Other kids don't think that's very important at all.		
5.			Some kids think that it's important to behave the way they should.	BUT	Other kids don't think that how they behave is that important.		
6.			Some kids don't think that getting good grades in school is all that important to how they feel about themselves.	BUT	Other kids think that getting good grades in school is important.		
7.			Some kids think it's important to be popular.	BUT	Other kids don't think that being popular is all that important to how they feel about themselves.		
8.			Some kids don't think doing well at athletics is that important to how they feel about themselves as a person.	BUT	Other kids feel that doing well at athletics is important.		
9.			Some kids don't think that how they look is important to how they feel about themselves as a person.	BUT	Other kids think that how they look is important.		
10.			Some kids don't think that how they behave is all that important.	BUT	Other kids think it's important to behave the way you are supposed to.		

© Harter 1985. Reproduced by kind permission of the author.
This measure is part of *Measures in Children's Mental Health & Psychological Wellbeing: A Portfolio for Education & Health Professionals*, edited by Norah Frederickson and Sandra Dunsmuir.
PPublished by GL Assessment, 9th Floor, 389 Chiswick High Road, London, W4 4ALJ

THE IMPORTANCE SCALE

GL Assessment

Scoring Grid

1.	4	3	Doing well at school	2	1
2.	1	2	Having a lot of friends	3	4
3.	4	3	Being good at sports	2	1
4.	4	3	Being good looking	2	1
5.	4	3	Behaving	2	1
6.	1	2	Getting good grades in school	3	4
7.	4	3	Being popular	2	1
8.	1	2	Doing well at athletics	3	4
9.	1	2	How they look	3	4
10.	1	2	How they behave	3	4

© Harter 1985. Reproduced by kind permission of the author.
This measure is part of *Measures in Children's Mental Health & Psychological Wellbeing: A Portfolio for Education & Health Professionals*, edited by Norah Frederickson and Sandra Dunsmuir.
Published by GL Assessment, 9th Floor, 389 Chiswick High Road, London, W4 4AJ.

THE IMPORTANCE SCALE

GL Assessment

Specific procedure for calculating the competence/importance discrepancy score

Step 1		Step 2		Step 3		Step 4	
Name of domains in which Importance Scores are 3.0, 3.5, or 4.0		Competence or Adequacy Scores (from the Self-Perception Profile)		Importance Ratings of 3, 3.5, and 4 only (from the Importance Scale)		Discrepancy Score **Sign (+ or –)**	**Value**
(a)			minus		equals		
(b)			minus		equals		
(c)			minus		equals		
(d)			minus		equals		
(e)			minus		equals		

Do **not** include domains in which Importance ratings are 2.5 or lower.
In most cases, this Discrepancy Score will be **negative**; however, it can also be zero or assume positive values.
The larger the negative discrepancy score, the more one's Importance scores exceed one's competence levels, and the lower one's self-worth score should be as a result.

Step 5		
Sum of Discrepancy Scores taking sign into account:	_____ (sign)	_____ (score)
Step 6		
Mean Discrepancy Score	_____ (sign)	_____ (score)
Step 7		
Transfer Global Self-Worth Score from the Self-Perception Profile, in order to compare.		

© Harter 1985. Reproduced by kind permission of the author.
This measure is part of *Measures in Children's Mental Health & Psychological Wellbeing: A Portfolio for Education & Health Professionals*, edited by Norah Frederickson and Sandra Dunsmuir.
Published by GL Assessment, 9th Floor, 389 Chiswick High Road, London, W4 4AJ.